

WESTERN PRE-1970s COMBAT AIRCRAFT

THE AIRCRAFT THAT SAW ACTION in Vietnam and in the Middle East during the 1960s and early 1970s were mostly designed during the 1950s. Some were extremely long-lived, like the subsonic Douglas Skyhawk, which first flew in 1954 and was still being used by the Argentinians in the 1982 Falklands War. Aircraft such as the F-100 Super Sabre and the Dassault Super Mystère belonged to the first generation of supersonic fighters, while the slightly later F-4 Phantom and Mirage III, show the progression to Mach 2 as a requirement for state-of-the-art fighters. The Dassault Mystère and Mirage series owed their fame to a political quirk which made France Israel's principal arms supplier in the years leading up to the 1967 Six-Day War. The Phantom, originally a US Navy jet, became arguably the foremost fighter of the decade. Both the Vought A-7 Corsair II, a light attack aircraft intended to succeed the Skyhawk, and the Grumman Intruder, were designed in the 1960s and first used in Vietnam. Both were still in frontline service at the time of the Gulf War in 1991.

WARSAW PACT FIGHTER

A lightweight, tactical fighter, the MiG-21 "Fishbed" made an excellent dogfighter. Its widespread export popularity lay in its relative cheapness – about one-third of the cost of a Phantom II. See pages 304–5.



Dassault Mirage III C

Development of the French delta-winged fighter was promoted enthusiastically by the French government. The highly successful Mirage III C was exported to many foreign air forces, including that of Argentina, which used them against British forces in the 1982 Falklands War.



ENGINE 13,225lb (6,000kg) thrust SNECMA Atar 9B turbojet	
WINGSPAN 27ft (8.2m)	LENGTH 50ft 10in (15.5m)
TOP SPEED 1,460mph (2,350kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 2 x 30mm DEFA cannon; up to 3,000lb (1,360kg) bombs, rockets, or missiles	

Dassault Super Mystère



Originally designated Mystère IV B, this was the first Western European aircraft to fly at supersonic speed and was retitled Super Mystère. An entirely French design, though taking several ideas from the American F-100, it also used a French-developed engine and was in French Air Force service from 1957.

ENGINE 9,920lb (4,500kg) thrust SNECMA Atar 101G-3 turbojet	
WINGSPAN 34ft 5in (10.5m)	LENGTH 14m (46ft 1in)
TOP SPEED 743mph (1,200kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 2 x 30mm DEFA cannon; internal launcher for 35 rockets, 2,000lb (910kg) bombload or weapons on wing pylons.	

Douglas A-4D Skyhawk

The US Navy's first jet attack bomber was so small and light that it was nicknamed "Heinemann's Hot Rod" after its designer. The aircraft was fast enough for the prototype to take the world 311 miles (500km) speed record. Entering service with the Navy and Marines from 1956, Skyhawks were frontline aircraft for 20 years.



ENGINE 8,500lb (3,860kg) thrust Pratt & Whitney J52-6 turbojet	
WINGSPAN 27ft 6in (8.4m)	LENGTH 40ft 1in (12.2m)
TOP SPEED 685mph (1,102kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 2 x 20mm cannon; 8,200lb (3,720kg) bombload	

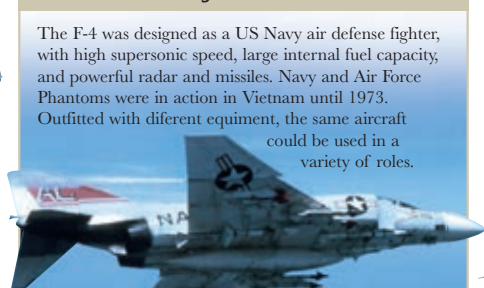
Grumman A-6E Intruder



This US Navy and Marine Corps all-weather attack bomber went straight into combat in Vietnam from 1965. The bulbous fuselage houses one of the most sophisticated navigation and attack radar systems in the world, including automatic landing on a parent carrier. Intruders were still extremely effective in the Gulf War.

ENGINE 2 x 9,300lb (4,220kg) thrust P&W J52-8A turbojet	
WINGSPAN 53ft (16.2m)	LENGTH 54ft 9in (16.7m)
TOP SPEED 644mph (1,037kph)	CREW 2
ARMAMENT up to 18,000lb (8,165kg) bombs, rockets, or missiles	

McDonnell Douglas F-4J Phantom II



The F-4 was designed as a US Navy air defense fighter, with high supersonic speed, large internal fuel capacity, and powerful radar and missiles. Navy and Air Force Phantoms were in action in Vietnam until 1973. Outfitted with different equipment, the same aircraft could be used in a variety of roles.

ENGINE 2 x 17,900lb (8,120kg) thrust GE J79-GE-10 turbojet	
WINGSPAN 38ft 4in (11.7m)	LENGTH 58ft 2in (17.7m)
TOP SPEED 1,500mph (2,414kph)	CREW 2
ARMAMENT 4 x AIM-9 Sidewinder and 4 x AIM-7 Sparrow anti-aircraft missiles; or 16,000lb (7,260kg) bombload	

North American F-100D Super Sabre

The prototype Super Sabre flew in 1953, breaking the sound barrier on its first flight. With extensive use of high-strength titanium alloys, it was a radical step forward in aircraft design and soon became one of the USAF's most versatile tactical aircraft, flying over 360,000 combat sorties in Vietnam.



ENGINE 16,950lb (7,690kg) thrust P&W J57-P-21A turbojet	
WINGSPAN 39ft (11.9m)	LENGTH 49ft (15m)
TOP SPEED 908mph (1,461kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 4 x 20mm M-39E cannon in fuselage; up to 7,040lb (3,190kg) of bombs, rockets, or missiles	